

LESSON 7

Navigating Weak Roots: I-Alaph, I-Yodh, and III-Yodh verbs

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSONS 5–6

Quick Summary

In Lessons 5 and 6, we expanded our vocabulary exponentially by learning how Semitic roots generate new meanings through derived stems. The **Aphel** stem (prefix *ʾa-*) generates causative verbs (e.g., God *ʾahyī* “gave life”). The **Paael** stem (doubled middle radical) generates intensive or factitive verbs (e.g., *qaddas* “he made holy”).

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. What stem does a verb belonging to the pattern *ʾaCCeC* belong to (e.g., *ʾaqreb*)?
 2. What consonant prefix marks the active participle of *all* derived stems (Aphel, Paael, etc.)?
 3. Translate: *Alāhā ʾaglī šrārā*.
 4. If *q-d-š* in Peal means “to be holy”, what does it mean in Paael (*qaddas*)?
 5. How would you recognize a Paael participle versus a Peal participle?
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SECTION 2: THE WEAK VERB CHALLENGE — OVERVIEW

Until now, we have mostly dealt with “strong” roots (like *k-t-b* or *š-b-q*), where all three consonants boldly assert themselves in every conjugation. However, some of the most common verbs in human language—to say, to be, to know, to give, to come—are “weak”. This means one of their three root consonants is a “weak letter” (Alaph, Waw, or Yodh), which tends to assimilate, drop out entirely, or turn into a vowel depending on the surrounding sounds.

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: Weak Consonants

Weak verbs are the bane of every Semitic language student, but they follow highly predictable phonetic rules.

- **Hebrew:** I-Guttural (אָמַר *’amar* = he said); I-Yod (יָדָע *yāda’* = he knew); Lamed-He/Yod (בָּנָה *bānāh* = he built).
 - **Arabic:** Hollow verbs (قَالَ *qāla* = he said); Defective/Final Weak (رَمَى *ramā* = he threw).
 - **Syriac:**
 - **I-Alaph:** Root *’-m-r* (to say) → *’emar* (not *’amar*).
 - **I-Yodh:** Root *y-d-’* (to know) → *īda’* (Yodh acts like an *i* vowel).
 - **III-Yodh:** Root *ḥ-z-y* (to see) → *ḥzā* (the Yodh drops out, leaving an *ā* vowel).
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SECTION 3: MORPHOLOGY OF WEAK ROOTS (PEAL PERFECT)

Despite the spelling changes, weak verbs function syntactically exactly like strong verbs: VSO word order, taking suffixes, and forming the spine of clauses.

1. I-Alaph Verbs (First consonant is Alaph)

The most famous is *’-m-r* (“to say”). In the Peal perfect 3rd masc singular, the vowel shifts to *e*:

- *’emar* (he said), rather than *’amar*.
- *’emret* (I said), rather than *’amret*.

2. I-Yodh Verbs (First consonant is Yodh)

Very common verbs like *y-d-’* (to know) and *y-t-b* (to sit). The initial **y** fuses with the preceding invisible glottal stop to form an *ī* vowel.

- *y-d-’* → *īda’* (he knew).
- *y-t-b* → *īteb* (he sat). *Note: The verb y-h-b (to give) is highly irregular and behaves like a strong verb without an internal vowel: yahb (he gave).*

3. III-Yodh Verbs (Third consonant is Yodh)

Verbs ending in Yodh (like *ḥ-z-y*, *b-n-y*, *ḥ-y-y*). The Yodh falls away in the 3rd masc singular, leaving a final *ā* vowel. In other persons, the Yodh can reappear as heavily vocalized endings.

- *ḥ-z-y* (to see) → *ḥzā* (he saw) [looks like a 2-consonant word].
- *ḥ-z-y* + *-et* (I saw) → *ḥzēt* (the *ay* contracts to *ē*).
- *ḥ-z-y* + *-ū* (They saw) → *ḥzaw* (the *ay-ū* contracts to *aw*).

SECTION 4: III-YODH PARADIGM (ROOT: Ḥ-Z-Y “TO SEE”)

Because III-Yodh verbs lose their third consonant so frequently, memorizing their exact endings is essential.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	TRANSLATION	NOTES
3 m.sg.	ܠܐ	ḥzā	he saw	Ends in <i>ā</i> (Alaph)
3 f.sg.	ܠܐܬ	ḥzāt	she saw	Ends in <i>āt</i>
2 m.sg.	ܠܝܬ	ḥzayt	you (m) saw	Yodh reappears, <i>ay</i> diphthong
2 f.sg.	ܠܝܬܝ	ḥzaytī	you (f) saw	Yodh reappears
1 c.sg.	ܠܝܬܝܬ	ḥzēt	I saw	Yodh contracts with <i>et</i> to <i>ēt</i>
3 m.pl.	ܠܝܬܝܬܝܬ	ḥzaw	they (m) saw	<i>w</i> makes <i>aw</i> diphthong
3 f.pl.	ܠܝܬܝܬܝܬܝܬ	ḥzay	they (f) saw	<i>y</i> makes <i>ay</i> diphthong
1 c.pl.	ܠܝܬܝܬܝܬܝܬܝܬ	ḥzayn	we saw	<i>ay</i> diphthong

SECTION 5: THE HIGHLY IRREGULAR VERBS ’-T-Y AND H-W-Y

Two of the most common verbs in Syriac are doubly weak and highly irregular.

1. **’-t-y** (to come): I-Alaph AND III-Yodh.
 - 3 m.s: *’etā* (he came).
 - 1 c.s: *’etēt* (I came).
 - 3 m.pl: *’etaw* (they came).
 2. **h-w-y** (to be/become): Used as an auxiliary verb, or to mean “it happened”. III-Yodh.
 - 3 m.s: *hwā* (he was / it happened).
 - 1 c.s: *hwēt* (I was).
 - 3 m.pl: *hwaw* (they were).
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SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (WEAK VERBS & COURT TERMS)

ROOT	PEAL PERFECT 3M.S.	MEANING	CLASSIFICATION
ʿ.מ.ר	ʿemar (עמר)	to say	I-Alaph
א.כ.ל	ʿekal (אכל)	to eat	I-Alaph
א.ז.ל	ʿezal (אזל)	to go	I-Alaph
י.ד.ע	īdaʿ (ידע)	to know	I-Yodh
י.ת.ב	īteb (יתב)	to sit	I-Yodh
י.ת.נ	yahb (יתן)	to give	I-Yodh (Irregular)
ר.א.ו	ḥzā (חזו)	to see	III-Yodh
ק.ר.א	qrā (קרא)	to call / read	III-Alaph (behaves like III-Yodh)
ב.נ.ה	bnā (בנה)	to build	III-Yodh
ח.י.ו	ḥyā (חי)	to live	III-Yodh
י.ת.א	ʿetā (עתא)	to come	I-Alaph & III-Yodh
ה.ו.א	hwā (הוא)	to be/become	III-Yodh
(Noun)	רִגְזָה (rūgzā)	anger/wrath	Emotion abstract
(Noun)	חֶמְצָן (hemzman)	word / report	Court term

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 7

The Summons

Narrative note: Pay attention to the massive use of weak roots— ʿemar (said), ʿezal (went), īdaʿ (knew), hwā (was/became), ḥzaw (they saw), ʿetā (came).

Sentence 1

כאד ʿemar Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā, ʿezalū qāšīšē l-wāt malkā. kad (when) ʿemar (said) Yūḥannan (John) meltā (the-word) d-Alāhā (of-God), ʿezalū (went) qāšīšē (the-elders/guards) l-wāt (to-the-presence-of) malkā (the-king). → When Yukhannan said the word of God, the guards went to the king.

Sentence 2

אָמַרְיִן לֵיהּ יָאָד 'יֵן-הֵנָּן מָא הַוָּא בִּתְרָא 'אַ! 'אַמְרִין (they-[are])-
saying) l-eh (to-him): yād 'īn (knowing) -hnan (are-we) mā (what) hwā (happened/was) b-tar 'ā (in-the-
gate)! → They say to him: “We know what happened at the gate!”

Sentence 3

הֲזַיִן גַּבְרָא, וְ- 'עֵמָר מֵלְתָא בִּישְׁתָּא. הֲזַיִן (we-saw) gabrā (a-man), w-
'emar (and-said) meltā (a-word) bīštā (evil-[f]). → “We saw a man, and he said an evil word.”

Sentence 4

הַוָּא הָשָׂא מַלְכָּא רַגִּיז תָּב. הַוָּא (became/was) hāšā (now) malkā (the-king)
ragīz (angry) ṭāb (greatly/very). → Now the king was very angry.

Sentence 5

אָמַרְתְּ, מַלְכָּא לְ-קַשִּׁישֵׁי: 'אֵיטָא-הֵי לְ-הַרְכָּא! 'עֵמָר (said) malkā
(the-king) l-qašīšē (to-the-guards): 'aytāw-hy (let-them-bring-him [Aphel imperative]) l-harkā (to-here)!
→ The king said to the guards: “Bring him here!”

Sentence 6

וְ- 'עָתָא יוֹהָנָן קְדָמַי מַלְכָּא. וְ- 'עָתָא (and-came) Yūhannan (John) qdām
(before) malkā (the-king). → And Yukhannan came before the king.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Weak Root Identification

Identify the root and grammatical form of these weak verbs:

1. הֲזַיִן (hẓēt)
2. אָמַרְתְּ ('emarū)
3. אָמַרְתְּ ('etā)
4. אָמַרְתְּ (yahbū)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

Conjugate the root ʾ-*m-r* (to say) in the Peal perfect for:

1. I said
2. We said
3. You (m.sg) said
4. They (m.pl) said

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following past narrative clauses involving weak verbs.

1. ʾEmarū qaššē meltā.
2. Ḥzayn nūhrā d-Alāhā b-tar ʿ ā.
3. W-īda ʿ malkā rūgzā (wrath).
4. Hwaw b- ʾ ar ʿ ā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following narrative sentences into Syriac transliteration. (Remember VSO order).

1. The evil king saw (ḥzā) the man.
2. We came (ʾ etayn) to the kingdom.
3. I gave (yahbet) the garment to the guard (*qaššā*).
4. John knew (*īda* ʿ) the word of God.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. Who did the guards go to?
2. What do the guards claim they saw and heard?
3. How did the king react to the news?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. Aphel. (Causative).
2. *Mīm* (m-). e.g., *ma 'lep, mḡaddeš*.
3. God revealed the truth.
4. To make holy / to sanctify.
5. The vowel pattern: *mḡaddeš* (Paael) vs *kāteb* (Peal). The Peal has no *m*- prefix in the active participle.

Exercise 1: Weak Root Identification

1. Root: *ḥ-z-y*. Form: Peal perfect, 1 c.sg (I saw).
2. Root: *'-m-r*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.pl (They said).
3. Root: *'-t-y*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.sg (He came).
4. Root: *y-h-b*. Form: Peal perfect, 3 m.pl (They gave).

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. *'emret*
2. *'emarn*
3. *'emart*
4. *'emarū*

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. The guards said a word.
2. We saw the light of God in the gate.
3. And the king knew wrath.
4. They were in the earth.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. *Ḥzā malkā bīšā l-gabrā*. (*l-* marks direct object).
2. *'Etain l-malkūtā*.
3. *Yahbet lbūšā l-qašīšā*.
4. *Īda ' Yūḥannan meltā d-Alāhā*.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. To the king.
2. A man who said an evil word.
3. He became very angry (*ragīz ṭāb*) and demanded the man be brought to him.

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

WEAK VERB SHIFT SUMMARY

CLASS	ROOT	SHIFT RULE	3 M.SG EXAMPLE	1 C.SG EXAMPLE
I-Alaph	'-m-r	First vowel becomes <i>e</i>	'emar (he said)	'emret (I said)
I-Yodh	y-d-'	Initial Yodh + stop → <i>ī</i>	īda' (he knew)	īd'et (I knew)
III-Yodh	ḥ-z-y	Yodh drops, ends in <i>ā</i> in 3ms	ḥzā (he saw)	ḥzēt (I saw)
Double Weak	'-t-y	Follows both rules	'etā (he came)	'etēt (I came)

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on

derived nouns (abstract and concrete) from weak roots and related weak-root vocabulary.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING	NOTES
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ʾūmūttā	f. noun	oneness, unity	from weak root ʾ - w-m
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	dēmūttā	f. noun	likeness, image	from root d-m-y (to be like)
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ḥazūttā	f. noun	vision, sight	from III-Yodh root ḥ-z-y
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	bənūttā	f. noun	building, structure	from III-Yodh root b-n-y
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ʿəlūttā	f. noun	ascent, exaltation	from I-Alaph root ʿ - l-y
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	qərūttā	f. noun	calling, vocation	from III-Alaph/Yodh root q-r-ʾ
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ʿawdērānā	m. noun	help, aid	from root ʿ - d-r
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	yāzəpā	m. noun	beauty, form	from root y-z-p
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ḥəbīyūnā	m. noun	gift, offering	from I-Yodh root y-h-b
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ʾətyānūttā	f. noun	coming, arrival	from weak root ʾ - t-y
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ḥəwīyūttā	f. noun	being, existence	from III-Yodh root h-w-y
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ʿālmūttā	f. noun	worldliness, temporality	from weak root ʿ - l-m
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	dūqā	m. noun	bench, throne	from weak root d-w-q
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	gūrā	m. noun	dwelling, cave	from weak root g-w-r
ᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎᵎ	ṭūprā	m. noun	appearance, form	from weak root ṭ-w-p-r

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING	NOTES
קָמָא	qūmā	m. noun	standing, resurrection	from I-Alaph/Yodh root q-y-m
נָפִי'	napī'ā	m. noun	seer, prophet	from I-Alaph root n-p-'
קֹוָא	'ōnā	m. noun	strength, power	from weak root ' - w-n
קָוָדַע	šūwəddā	m. noun	testimony, witness	from weak root š-w-d
קָוָוָא	rūmūttā	f. noun	highness, exaltation	from weak root r-w-m
קָרָא	qerā	m. noun	cold	from weak root q-r-
קָלָמָא	ḥelmā	m. noun	dream	from weak root ḥ-l-m
קָדָא	dūsā	m. noun	trampling, subjugation	from weak root d-w-s
קָלָלָא	ləlūttā	f. noun	lamenting, wailing	from weak root l-l-y
קָרָא	pūrā	m. noun	fruit	from weak root p-w-r
קָוָא	'ūqqānā	m. noun	knot, binding	from weak root ' - q-d
קָלָלָא	šəlyānā	m. noun	peace, wholeness	from weak root š-l-y
קָוָוָא	'ətwūttā	f. noun	sign, omen	from weak root ' - t-w
קָוָא	nūttā	f. noun	rest, dwelling	from weak root n-w-t
קָוָוָא	wayrūttā	f. noun	shame, disgrace	from weak root w-y-r